

THE PLANT THAT CHANGED THE WORLD

Countless types of tea are produced and enjoyed globally, and although they might look and taste very different, they are all made from the leaves of the versatile evergreen plant, *Camellia sinensis*.

CAMELLIA SINENSIS

There are two main varieties of *Camellia sinensis*. The first, *Camellia sinensis* var. *sinensis*, produces teas with flavors ranging from bright and fresh to rich and malty. It is a small-leaved plant suited to a cool, misty climate, such as on the higher elevations of mountainous regions in China, Taiwan, and Japan. This variety can grow to

a height of 20ft (6m) if left undisturbed. The second, *Camellia sinensis* var. *assamica*, is a larger-leaved plant that thrives in tropical regions, such as India, Sri Lanka, and Kenya. Its leaves can grow as long as 8in (20cm) and, in the wild, it can grow to a height of 50ft (15m). This variety produces teas with flavors ranging from mellow and grassy to brisk and malty.

CULTIVARS: THE CHARACTER OF A PLANT

One of the characteristics of the tea plant is its ability to adapt naturally to its ambient conditions, making it wholly suited to the region in which it is grown. Growers often build upon distinguishing traits of their tea plants by creating “cultivars,” or cultivated varieties. They do this by selecting plants with distinct qualities, such as special flavor attributes or an ability to endure drought or repel insects.

As a result of human intervention, as well as natural occurrence, there are now more than 500 hybrids of tea plant. Some of these are bred exclusively for a specific type of tea, such as the Da Bai Hao cultivar for Silver Needle white tea, or Japanese Yabukita, the most popular cultivar in Japan.



TEA CULTIVATION

A typical terraced plantation on the slopes of the Cameron Highlands in Malaysia (above). *Camellia sinensis* var. *sinensis* (right) produces nuanced flavors because of its slow growth.